

Mrs. Kramer had a good sense of fashion and instilled in her daughters the importance of looking well for every occasion. She enjoyed sewing, and would make her girls stylish outfits for holidays and special events.

When Mr. Kramer died, the church was supportive, bringing casseroles for two weeks and offering help: "Please let me know if there's anything I can do." The people were sincere, but Mrs. Kramer knew it was up to her to support herself and her two children.

She went to a neighborhood dry cleaners that advertised alterations, but they were not hiring. However, they said they could use her services on an as-needed basis for minor alterations, replacing zippers, and other such work. But while this brought in a little cash, it was by far too little and too irregular to pay bills.

Beth's mother was an intelligent woman, but she and her husband had never discussed finances. She was responsible for the home, and her husband was responsible for the checkbook and household management. Two months after his death she was receiving past due notices and threats to cut off utilities because she hadn't paid the bills.

She went to the bank and confided to a manager her need to understand how to handle a checkbook. He was kind, and took her to his office. He produced a sample checkbook, opened it to the first check, and explained, "This is check number one." Mrs. Kramer told Beth years later, "I can still feel my face burning with embarrassment." The banker went on to show her how to record deposits, subtract check amounts, and reconcile her statement every month. She soon became quite good at managing.

After a few months, Mrs. Kramer went to her pastor and explained her need to earn a living to see if he had any ideas. Pastor McCoy worked with her to determine what experiences and abilities she had, and finally suggested she use her homemaking talents to open a catering business. She was agreeable, and the pastor made contacts